over the wound as the pain kept increasing. I told Anjaria and V.K. Singh that I did not want to be evacuated till someone responsible could take control of the operation. It was about 11.30 a.m. by then.

The brigade second-in-command, Colonel U.R. Chaudhri, arrived with the medical officer in about an hour. The tactical situation was explained to him and he took charge. Meanwhile, the doctor dressed my wound afresh and gave a shot of morphine, a very effective painkiller and the saviour of wounded soldiers ever since the First World War. As taught in medical schools, he put down details such as the dose administered along with the time at which the tranquillizer was injected, on the huge white sterilized bandage itself, and wrote out a brief medical report. As happens with a 'high velocity and spinning hardnosed' bullet of a 7.62-calibre 'Dragunov' sniper rifle, which I suspect was the type of weapon used to target me, it went through my groin making a hole the size of a small coin, but the exit wound in the buttock was about two square inches of shattered blood vessels, nerves and flesh, with blood all over! Intermittent firing continued to take place as I was evacuated on a stretcher to the road where a jonga (MUV) ambulance was waiting. From there, it took us about two hours to reach the nearest helipad, and I was flown to Srinagar in the waiting chopper.